

- RAG Learning

2.5 Anarchism

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 2: Non-core Political Ideas, Section B

Exam Tip: This is one of **five** non-core ideas. You sit **one** of Anarchism, Ecologism, Feminism, Multiculturalism or Nationalism, answering a single 24-mark "To what extent" question (AO1 8 / AO2 8 / AO3 8). Learn your chosen idea properly rather than all five thinly.

Anarchism rejects the state and all compulsory authority. It is the only ideology on the specification that has never held power, which makes the "is it utopian" question unavoidable — and gives you a ready-made evaluative line.

Anarchism — rejection of the state and of all coercive authority over the individual.

Anarchy — the absence of rule; for anarchists a condition of order without government, not disorder.

Collectivism — people achieve more through co-operation than through individual effort.

Mutual aid — Kropotkin's argument that co-operation is a factor in evolution alongside competition.

Mutualism — Proudhon's system of voluntary exchange between independent producers on fair terms.

Egoism — Stirner's doctrine that the individual should recognise no authority above their own will.

Anarcho-syndicalism — revolutionary trade unions taking over production as the units of a stateless society.

Anarcho-capitalism — abolition of the state with protection supplied by competing private agencies.

Direct action — political action outside the institutions of the state.

1. Core ideas and principles

Principle	What it means
Anti-statism	The state rests on coercion and compels obedience without genuine consent. The objection is to the state as such — a democratic state remains coercive
Liberty	Freedom means living under rules one has actually agreed to. Even a minimal state violates this, which is where anarchism parts from liberalism
Human nature	Malleable and capable of co-operation. Selfishness is produced by the state, hierarchy and capitalism, not by nature
Natural order	Order arises spontaneously from voluntary co-operation, custom and mutual interest, without coercive authority
Anti-clericalism	Organised religion is a further form of hierarchy and imposed authority
Economic freedom	Rejection of economic arrangements that produce domination — though strands disagree sharply about which those are

Why anarchists reject representative democracy: electing a representative transfers one's will to another and recreates authority over oneself. Voting legitimises the state by participating in it. This is a more radical position than it first appears and worth stating precisely — anarchists object to democratic states, not only to authoritarian ones.

2. Collectivist and individualist strands

	Collectivist	Individualist
Freedom is realised through	Co-operative common ownership and voluntary association	The sovereignty of the individual against every collective claim
Human nature	Naturally social and co-operative	Self-directing; owes nothing to others

Economy	Common ownership (Kropotkin) or mutualist exchange (Proudhon)	Voluntary exchange; for anarcho-capitalists, private property and markets
Thinkers	Proudhon, Bakunin, Kropotkin	Stirner; Goldman spans both

They share an enemy and hold opposite views of what should replace it. That is the **central tension** in the ideology, and the readiest answer to "to what extent do anarchists agree".

3. Key thinkers

Max Stirner (1806–56) — *The Ego and Its Own* (1844). Egoism: the individual should recognise no authority above their own will and interests. Abstractions — the state, God, humanity, morality — are "spooks" that enslave the individual who accepts them. The only association he permits is a voluntary "union of egoists", dissolved the moment it ceases to serve its members.

Pierre-Joseph Proudhon (1809–65) — *What is Property?* (1840). "Property is theft" — but the target is property that rests on exploiting others' labour, not *possession* based on use, which he defends. **Mutualism**: voluntary exchange between independent producers on fair terms, supported by a people's bank offering credit without interest. **Federalism**: autonomous communes linked by voluntary contracts, revocable at will. The first person to call himself an anarchist.

Mikhail Bakunin (1814–76) — collectivist anarchism. Freedom is social: "I am truly free only when all human beings around me are equally free." Opposed Marx in the First International, warning that a workers' state would become a new ruling class — in effect a dictatorship over the proletariat rather than of it (a paraphrase, not his exact words) — because any group holding state power acquires an interest in keeping it. The twentieth century is usually treated as vindicating him.

Peter Kropotkin (1842–1921) — *Mutual Aid* (1902). Drawing on observation as a naturalist, he argued that **co-operation** is a factor in evolution and survival alongside competition, so human sociability is natural rather than imposed. **Anarcho-communism**: a federation of self-governing communes holding property in common and distributing according to need.

Emma Goldman (1869–1940) — liberation requires freedom from the state, from capitalism *and* from the constraints imposed on women in private life, including in marriage and sexuality. She criticised the vote as a route to emancipation: participating in the state legitimises it, and the ballot cannot reach the private and economic relations where subordination actually operates. Bridges anarchism and feminism.

Exam Tip: Bakunin's critique of Marx is the highest-value argument in this topic because it works in two directions: it is anarchism's strongest claim, and it anticipates what happened to Marxist revolutions. Pair it with Luxemburg's parallel objection from inside Marxism if a question invites comparison with socialism.

4. Anarchism on the state, society, the economy and human nature

	Position	Internal disagreement
The state	Must be abolished; coercive and corrupting by nature	None — this is the defining agreement
Society	Order without government, through custom, federation and voluntary association	Communal and collective, or an association of sovereign individuals
The economy	Arrangements producing domination must go	Common ownership, mutualist exchange, or free-market private property

Human nature	Malleable, capable of co-operation once authority is removed	Naturally social (Kropotkin) or naturally self-directing (Stirner)
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Is anarcho-capitalism anarchist?

It rejects the state entirely, so on pure anti-statism it qualifies. Collectivist anarchists reply that private property and market power are themselves coercive: an employer's power over an employee, a landlord's over a tenant, is domination whether or not a state enforces it. Proudhon's distinction between property and possession rules out capitalist ownership directly. The disagreement mirrors the negative–positive freedom dispute in liberalism, which is why anarcho-capitalism is often classed as radical liberalism instead.

5. Strengths and criticisms

Strengths	Criticisms
A consistent critique of concentrated power that other traditions cannot make from the inside, having accepted the state	No account of how a complex society coordinates at scale — energy, pandemics, supply chains
Its warning about the transitional state was borne out	Nothing prevents new hierarchies forming once the restraining institutions are gone — an objection internal to its own analysis
Real instances exist: Catalonia 1936–37, the Free Territory in Ukraine, co-operatives and communes	Those instances were short-lived and small; none scaled or endured
Wide influence on later movements — horizontal organisation, consensus decision-making, direct action, prefigurative politics	Refusing to contest elections guarantees exclusion from outcomes
Its account of human nature is not obviously wrong — mutual aid describes real behaviour	The central empirical claim is untestable at scale

Exam Tip: For "To what extent is anarchism utopian?", the strongest judgement concedes the force of the charge and reframes it: anarchism's own analysis — that power corrupts and those holding it acquire an interest in keeping it — applies to whatever arises after the state is gone. So it describes a condition to be continually maintained rather than a settlement to be reached, which is close to what "utopian" means. That is a better conclusion than either defending or dismissing the ideology.

Quick recall

- Core: anti-statism, liberty, malleable human nature, natural order, anti-clericalism, economic freedom
- Collectivist (Proudhon, Bakunin, Kropotkin) against individualist (Stirner; Goldman spans both)
- Stirner: egoism, "spooks", the union of egoists
- Proudhon: property is theft but possession is legitimate; mutualism; federalism; the first self-described anarchist
- Bakunin: a workers' state becomes a dictatorship over the proletariat
- Kropotkin: mutual aid as a factor in evolution; anarcho-communism
- Goldman: the state, capitalism *and* private-sphere constraints; scepticism about the vote
- Anarchism rejects democratic states too — voting transfers the will and legitimises the state